Speaker commitment in constructions with propositional verbs in Russian

Daria Popova, HSE

Formal Philosophy 2026

30.10.2026

Speaker commitment contrast

Jackendoff (1972), Asher (2000), and Murray (2014) draw a sharp empirical distinction between denials of main clause claims in parenthetical constructions (1a, 2a) and denials of embedded claims (1b, 2b) in constructions with propositional verbs in English.

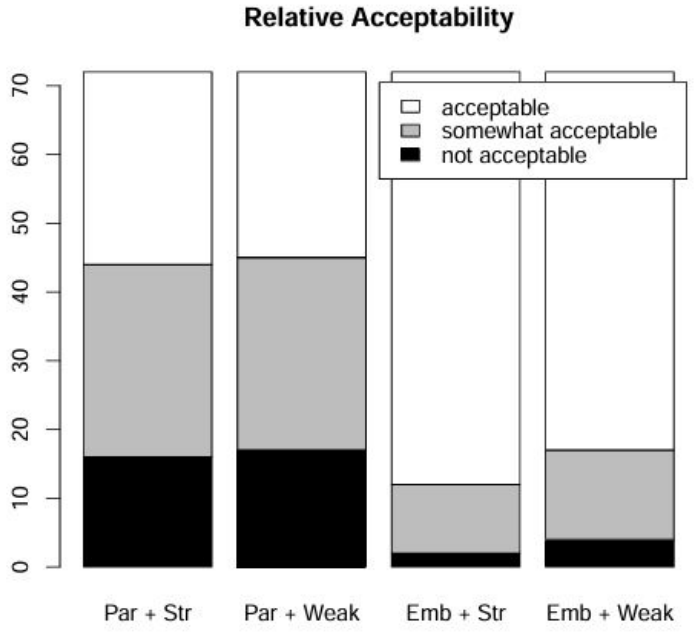
(1) (Jackendoff 1972: 97)
a. Myrtle will come tomorrow, Margaret believes, (#but she actually came yesterday).
b. Margaret believes that Myrtle will come tomorrow, but she actually came yesterday.

(2) (Asher 2000: 36)
a. #John, Mary assures us, can be trusted, but I don’t trust him.
b. Mary assures us that John can be trusted, but I don’t trust him.

Speaker commitment contrast

- Koev (2021) tested the contrast experimentally and found that while the contrast is real, it is not a categorical one but rather a matter of degree.
- Main clause claims in parenthetical constructions can be hedged, but are significantly more difficult to hedge than embedded ones.
- It suggests that the speaker is committed to the main clause claims in parenthetical constructions, but is not necessarily committed to embedded claims.

Lucy bought a new car, my brother said, but she actually didn't.
My brother said that Lucy bought a new car, but she actually didn't.
Lucy bought a new car, my brother said, but she might not have.
My brother said that Lucy bought a new car, but she might not have.



Speaker commitment contrast

- a regular embedding:

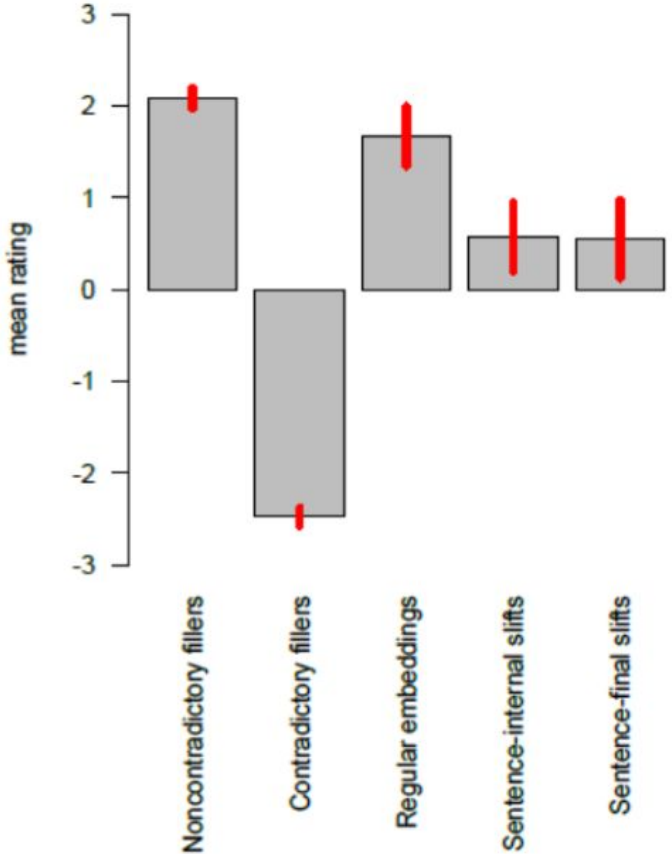
Mary said that Sam is running for political office, but he isn't.

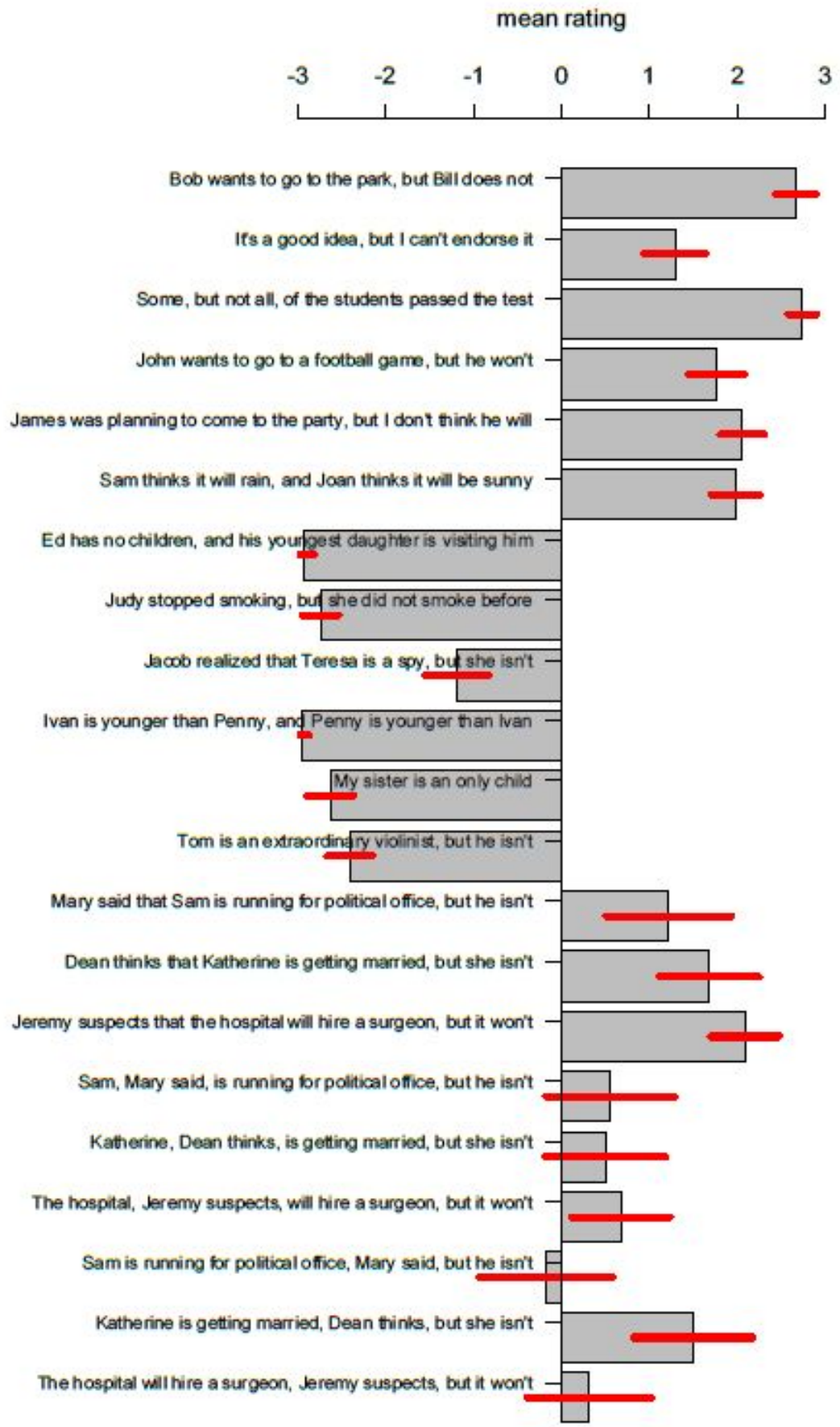
- a sentence-internal slift:

Katherine is, Dean thinks, getting married, but she isn't.

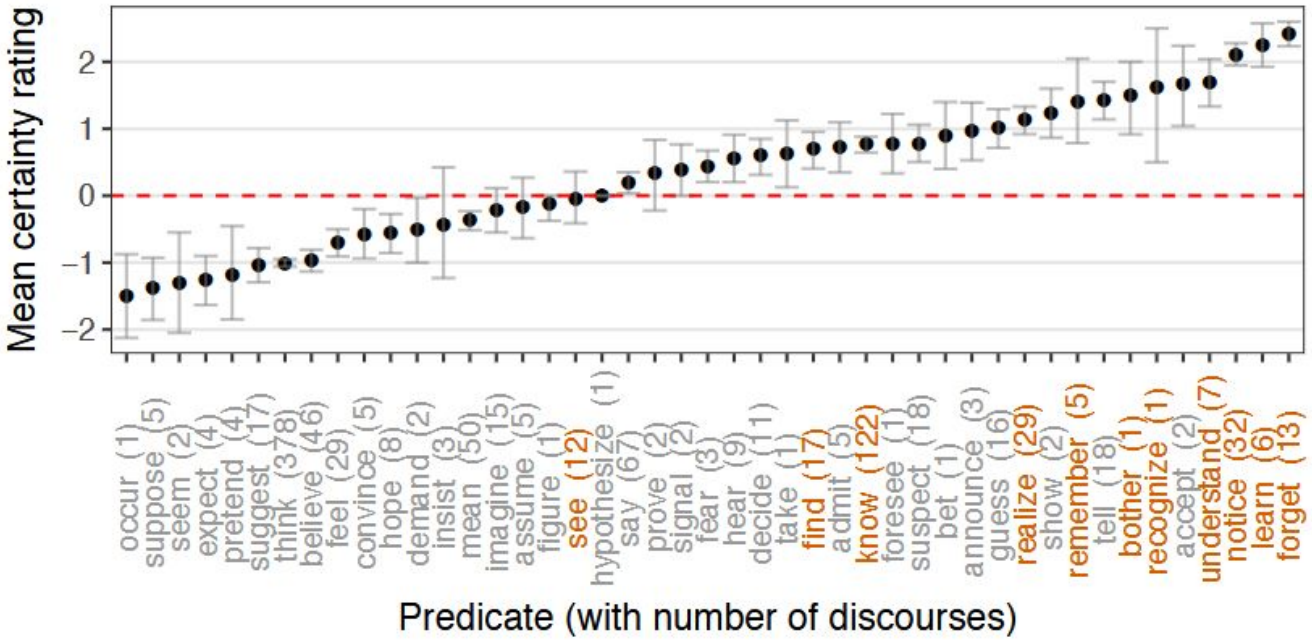
- a sentence-final slift:

The hospital will hire a surgeon, Jeremy suspects, but it won't.




mean rating
-3
-2
-1
0
1
2
3
Bob wants to go to the park, but Bill does not
It's a good idea, but I can't endorse it
Some, but not all, of the students passed the test
John wants to go to a football game, but he won't
James was planning to come to the party, but I don't think he will
Sam thinks it will rain, and Joan thinks it will be sunny
Ed has no children, and his youngest daughter is visiting him
Judy stopped smoking, but she did not smoke before
Jacob realized that Teresa is a spy, but she isn't
Ivan is younger than Penny, and Penny is younger than Ivan
My sister is an only child
Tom is an extraordinary violinist, but he isn't
Mary said that Sam is running for political office, but he isn't
Dean thinks that Katherine is getting married, but she isn't
Jeremy suspects that the hospital will hire a surgeon, but it won't
Sam, Mary said, is running for political office, but he isn't
Katherine, Dean thinks, is getting married, but she isn't
The hospital, Jeremy suspects, will hire a surgeon, but it won't
Sam is running for political office, Mary said, but he isn't
Katherine is getting married, Dean thinks, but she isn't
The hospital will hire a surgeon, Jeremy suspects, but it won't

Speaker commitment contrast



de Marneffe et al. (2019)

Speaker commitment contrast

- Russian data also shows significant variation in implicative potential of propositional verbs (Zalizniak 1988; 1992)
- which suggests that there might be contrasts in speaker commitment.

1a. Иван подозревает/, что его обманули \ (non-factive)
1b. Иван подозревает \, что его обманули (factive)

The Roadmap

- Examine the contrast in speaker commitment experimentally
- Explore the discourse behavior of regular embeddings and slifts
- Connect the differences in speaker commitment with the differences in discourse behavior
- Formalize regular embeddings and slifts in terms of updates: impositions and proposals
- Re-examine the results of the experiment

The Experiment: experimental set-up

- 8×3 design, **Propositional Verb Lexeme** (*dumat'* 'think' vs. *schitat'* 'believe' vs. *nadejat'sja* 'hope' vs. *podozrevat'* 'suspect' vs. *skazat'* 'say' vs. *obnaruzhit'* 'find out' vs. *ponjat'* 'realize' vs. *uznat'* 'learn') **× Construction Type** (Sentence-Internal Parenthetical vs. Sentence-Final Parenthetical vs. Regular Embedding)
- Three target sentences per experimental list:

(1) Ваня думает, что Катя выходит замуж, но это не так. RE

(2) На факультете, Станислав подозревает, сменят декана, но это не так. IS

(3) Вася талантливый поэт, Фрося считает, но это не так. FS

The Experiment: experimental set-up

Six non-contradictory fillers:

1. Валентина хочет пойти в Ботанический Сад, а Даша не хочет.
2. Это хорошая идея, но я не могу её поддержать.
3. Некоторые, но не все, студенты сдали контрольную.
4. Олег хочет пойти на футбол, но не сможет.
5. Наташа думает, что пойдет дождь, а Витя считает, что будет солнечно.
6. Настя планирует пойти в клуб, но не думаю, что она пойдет.

The Experiment: experimental set-up

Six contradictory fillers:

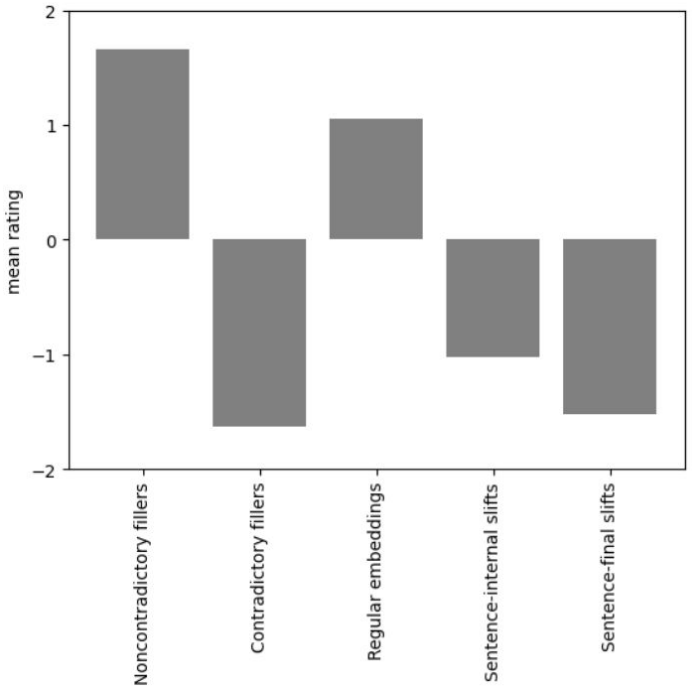
1. У Ксении нет детей, и её младшая дочь сейчас у неё в гостях.
2. Алина старше Ильи, а Илья старше Алины.
3. Денис -- выдающийся пианист, но это не так.
4. Мой брат -- единственный ребёнок.
5. Ваня понял, что Оля ему изменяет, но она ему не изменяет.
6. Паша бросил курить, но раньше он не курил.

The Experiment: experimental set-up

- A hundred people were recruited to participate in the study.
- All the participants self-identified as native speakers of Russian, aged 21 to 76, 86% female.
- Participants were asked to give each stimulus a score on a scale ranging from -3 (contradictory sentence) to 3 (non-contradictory sentence) with one point increments.

The Experiment: experimental results

- The ratings of regular embeddings are significantly higher than the ratings of both types of slifts (Wilcoxon rank sum test, $p < 0.001$)
- The ratings of non-contradictory fillers are significantly higher than the ratings of regular embeddings (Wilcoxon rank sum test, $p < 0.01$)
- The ratings of sentence-internal slifts differ significantly from the ratings of sentence-final slifts (Wilcoxon rank sum test, $p < 0.05$)
- An ordinal logistic regression model revealed that construction type is a highly significant factor for acceptability ($\beta = 1.629$, $SE = 0.307$, $z = 5.305$, $p < 0.001$).



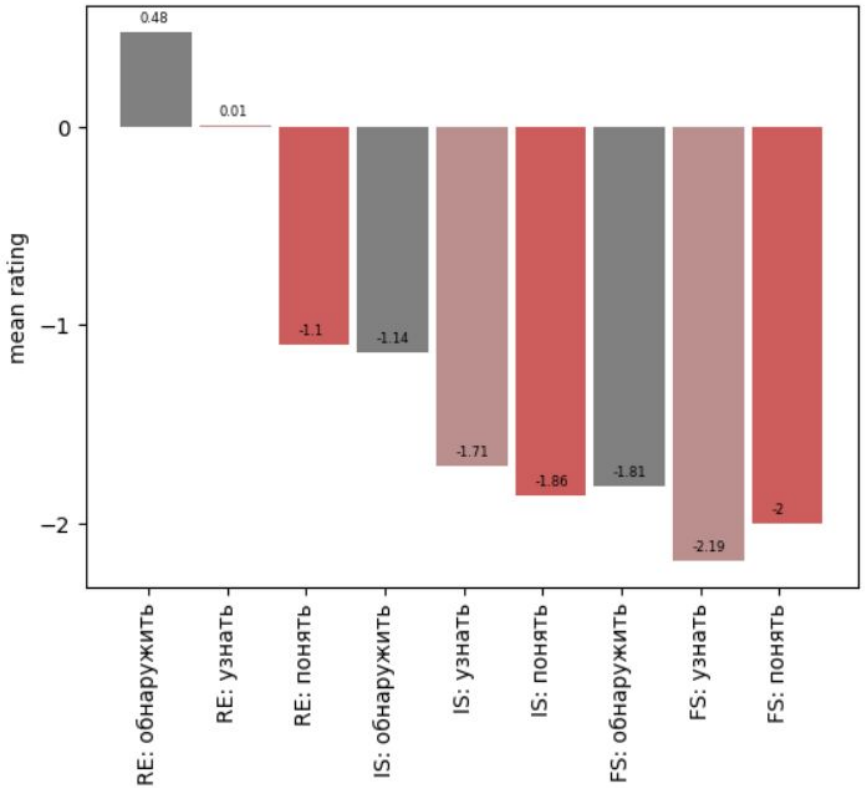
The Experiment: experimental results

- *obnaruzhit'* 'find out' < *uznat'* 'learn' < *ponjat'* 'realize'
- Таисия обнаружила, что доцентам повысили зарплату, но это не так.
- Виталий узнал, что конференция отменена, но это не так.
- Митя понял, что Стелла уехала, но это не так.
- additional factor: past tense of the proposition
- Zalizniak (1988) characterizes these predicates as factive, with a caveat:

a. Он понял\, что мне это не понравилось (factive)

b. Он понял/, что мне это не понравилось\... но он ошибается. (non-factive)

- *obnaruzhit'* 'find out', *uznat'* 'learn', *ponjat'* 'realize' behave like factive, rather than semi-factive verbs
- linear order matters

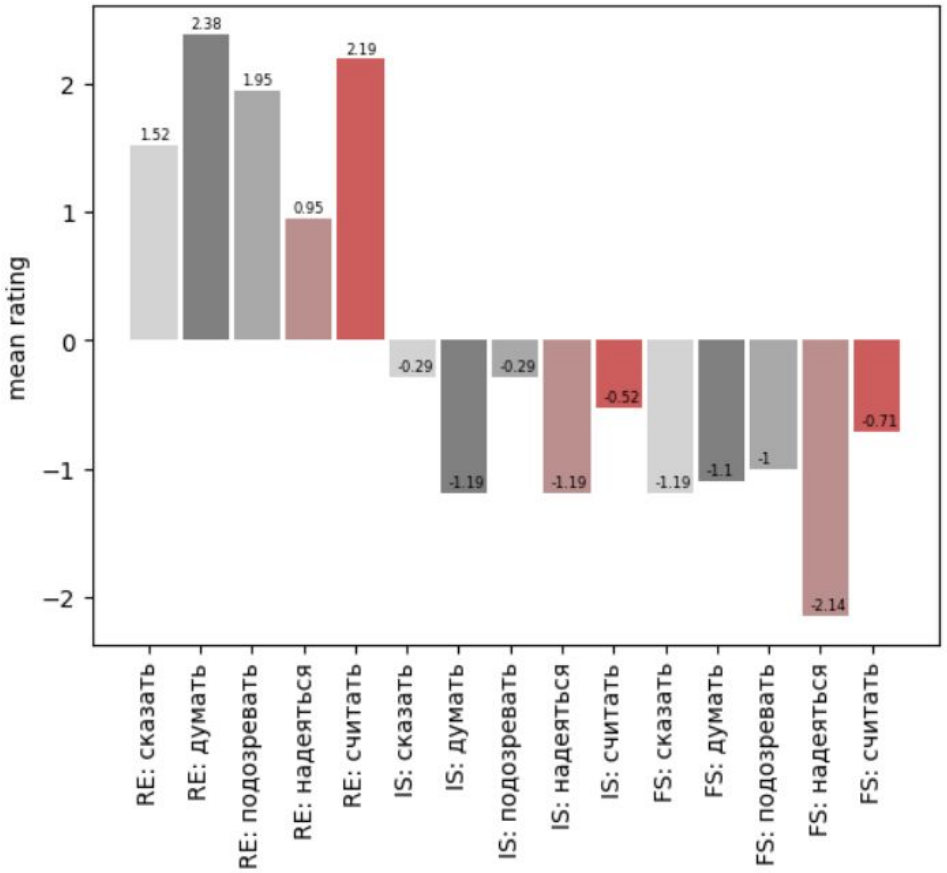


The Experiment: experimental results

- *dumat'* 'think' < *schitat'* 'believe' < *podozrevat'* 'suspect' < *skazat'* 'say' < *nadejat'sja* 'hope'
- Маша сказала, что Петя будет баллотироваться в Думу, но это не так.
- Ваня думает, что Катя выходит замуж, но это не так.
- Станислав подозревает, что на факультете сменят декана, но это не так.
- Павел надеется, что статью взяли на рассмотрение, но это не так.
- Фрося считает, что Вася талантливый поэт, но это не так.
- Zalizniak (1988, 1992):
- *dumat'* 'think' vs. *schitat'* 'believe': belief-stipulation vs. belief-evaluation: probability vs. truth conditions
- *podozrevat'* 'suspect' is also probabilistic, shows variation:

a. Иван подозревает/, что его обманули\, (non-factive)
b. Иван подозревает\, что его обманули (factive)

- *nadejat'sja* 'hope' includes evaluative component
- additional factor: past tense of the proposition



The Experiment: experimental results

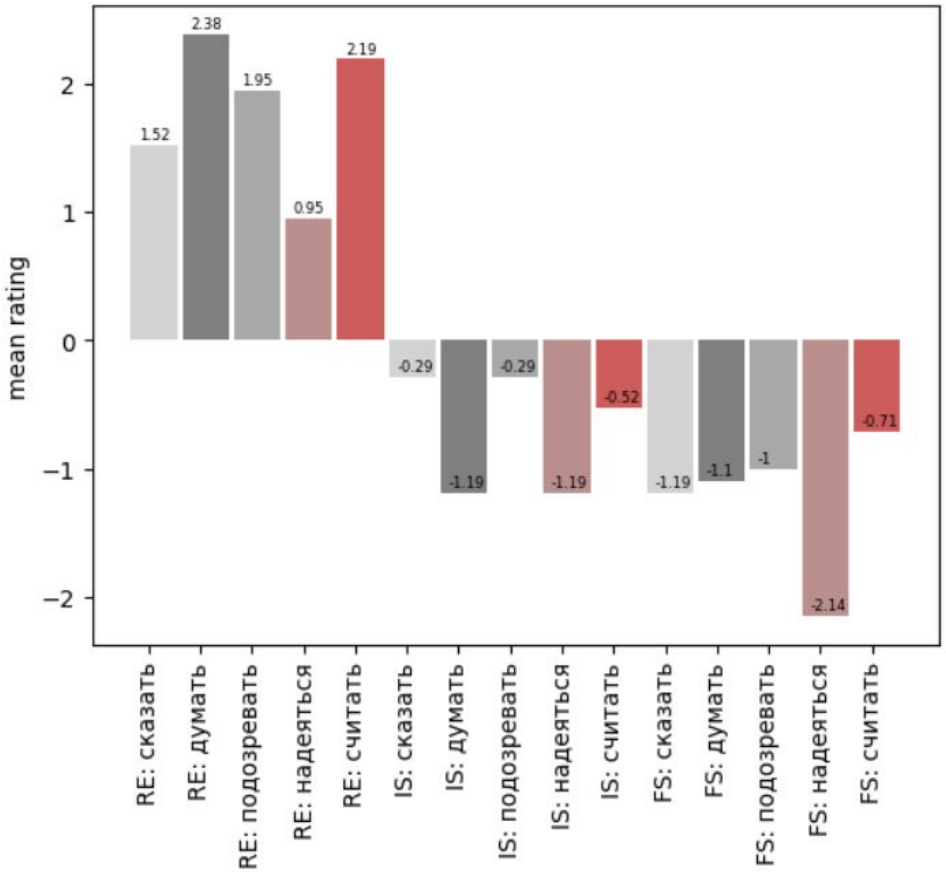
- *schitat'* 'believe' < *podozrevat'* 'suspect' < *dumat'* 'think' < *skazat'* 'say' < *nadejat'sja* 'hope'

- Петя будет баллотироваться в Думу, Маша сказала, но это не так.
- Катя выходит замуж, Ваня думает, но это не так.
- На факультете сменят декана, Станислав подозревает, но это не так.
- Статью взяли на рассмотрение, Павел надеется, но это не так.
- Вася талантливый поэт, Фрося считает, но это не так.

- Zalizniak (1988, 1992):
- *dumat'* 'think' vs. *schitat'* 'believe': belief-stipulation vs. belief-evaluation: probability vs. truth conditions
- *podozrevat'* 'suspect' is also probabilistic, shows variation:

a. Иван подозревает/, что его обманули\, (non-factive)
b. Иван подозревает\, что его обманули (factive)

- *nadejat'sja* 'hope' includes evaluative component
- additional factor: past tense of the proposition
- linear order matters



The Experiment: experimental results

- Construction type is a highly significant factor for acceptability
- Lexical semantics of the propositional verb plays a role
- Linear order plays a role
- Other linguistic factors, e.g. past tense, play a role

The Roadmap

- Examine the contrast in speaker commitment experimentally
- Explore the discourse behavior of regular embeddings and slifts
- Connect the differences in speaker commitment with the differences in discourse behavior
- Formalize regular embeddings and slifts in terms of updates: impositions and proposals
- Re-examine the results of the experiment

Discourse behavior: slifts and embeddings

In slifts, the embedded proposition (Катя выходит замуж) can answer a QUD, can be negated in the following discourse, while the attitude predication (Ваня сказал, что Катя выходит замуж) cannot, it is discourse inert:

(1) A: Кто выходит замуж? *Who is getting married?*

B: Катя, Ваня сказал, выходит замуж. *Katja, Vanja said, is getting married.*

(2) A: *Who said that Katja is getting married?*

B: #Катя, Ваня сказал, выходит замуж. *Katja, Vanja said, is getting married.*

(3) A: Катя, Ваня сказал, выходит замуж. *Katja, Vanja said, is getting married.*

B: Нет. *No (Katja is not getting married/#Vanja did not say that).*

Discourse behavior: slifts and embeddings

In embeddings, both the embedded proposition (Катя выходит замуж) and the attitude predication (Ваня сказал, что Катя выходит замуж) can answer a QUD, can be negated in the following discourse:

(1) A: Кто выходит замуж? *Who is getting married?*

B: Ваня сказал, что Катя выходит замуж. *Vanja said that Katja is getting married.*

(2) A: *Who said that Katja is getting married?*

B: Ваня сказал, что Катя выходит замуж. *Vanja said that Katja is getting married.*

(3) A: Ваня сказал, что Катя выходит замуж. *Vanja said that Katja is getting married.*

B: Нет. *No (Katja is not getting married/Vanja did not say that).*

Update semantics: embeddings vs. slifts

Discourse updates:

imposition (AnderBois et al. 2015): an informative non-negotiable update of the common ground

proposal (Farkas and Bruce 2010): an informative negotiable update of the common ground

(a) a regular embedding update for
Vanja said that Katja is getting married

Katja is getting married – a proposal
Vanja said that Katja is getting married – an imposition

OR

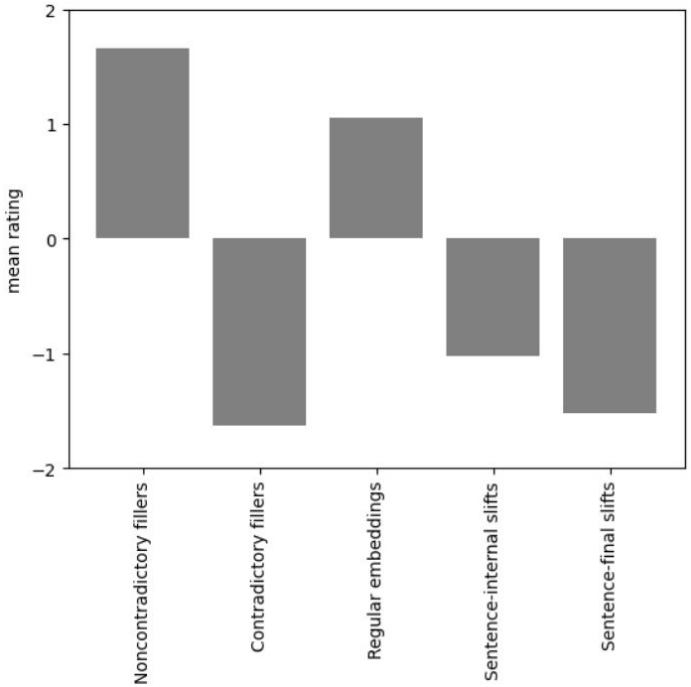
Vanja said that Katja is getting married – a proposal

(b) a corresponding slifting update for
Katja is getting married, Vanja said

Katja is getting married – a proposal
Vanja said that Katja is getting married – an imposition

Back to experimental results

- Regular embeddings like *Vanja said that Katja is getting married* are proposed, up for negotiation, the speaker is committed to the fact that Vanja said that, not necessarily to the fact that Katja is getting married.
- In slifts like *Katja is getting married, Vanja said* the proposition Katja is getting married is being proposed, the speaker is committed to the fact that Katja is getting married.



Back to experimental results

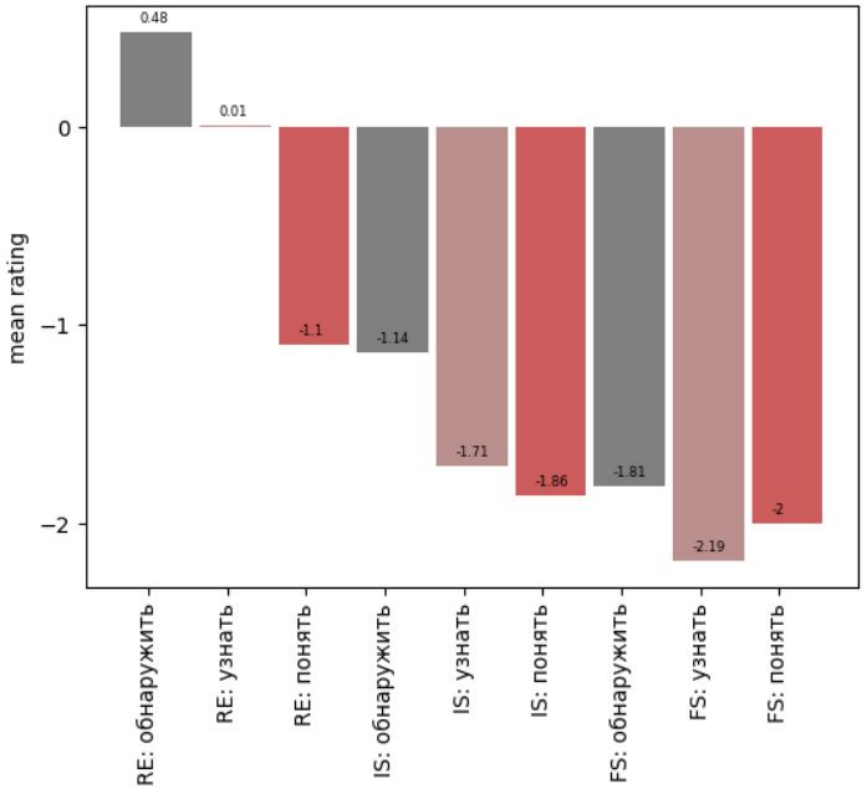
- *obnaruzhit'* 'find out', *uznat'* 'learn', *ponjat'* 'realize' behave like factive, rather than semi-factive verbs
- linear order matters
- Semi-factives (Karttunen 1971) can engage the discourse with both, the content of the attitude predication (1) and with the content of the semantically embedded proposition (2):

(1) A: *Who discovered that Dean has left town?*
B: *Sam discovered that he's left town.*

(2) A: *Who has left town?*
B: *Sam discovered that Dean has left town.*
B: *Dean has left town, Sam discovered.*

- Since in the semi-factive strategy the attitude predication can be imposed and the embedded predication can be proposed, it is compatible with the slifting strategy:

(3) *He sounded,* ***he realized****, like the old magazine articles he'd started his career penciling up - genteel, bumptious, and with titles like " The Ideal Gimlet. "* (COCA)



Back to experimental results

- *obnaruzhit'* 'find out', *uznat'* 'learn', *ponjat'* 'realize' behave like factive, rather than semi-factive verbs
- linear order matters
- a factive regular embedding update for
  Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire

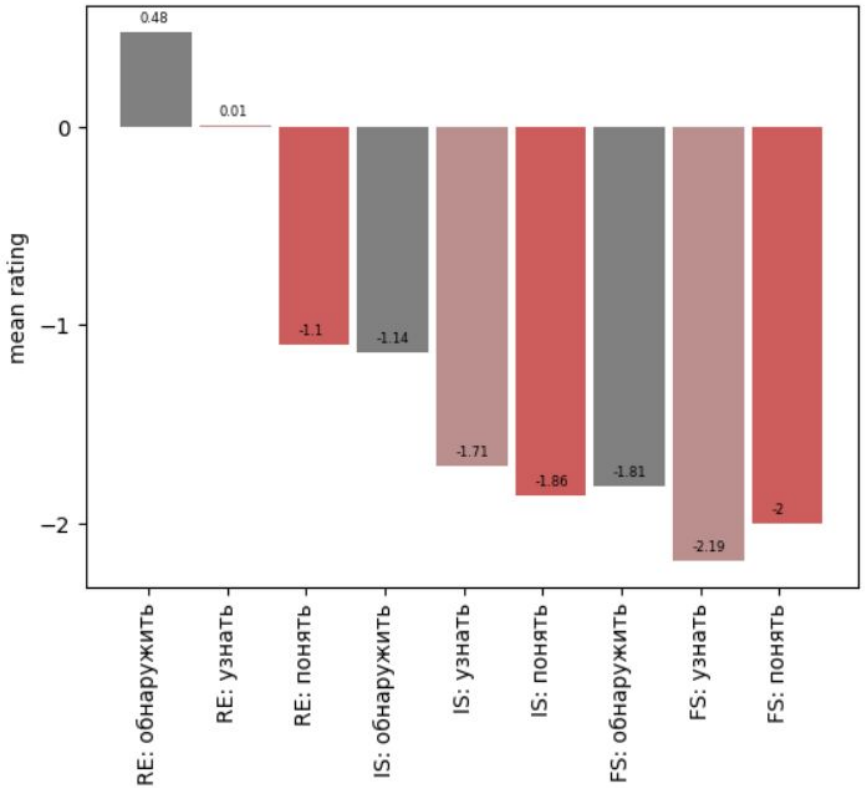
  Bella is a vampire – an imposition

  Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire – a proposal

- a corresponding slifting update for
  **Bella is a vampire, Sam is happy*

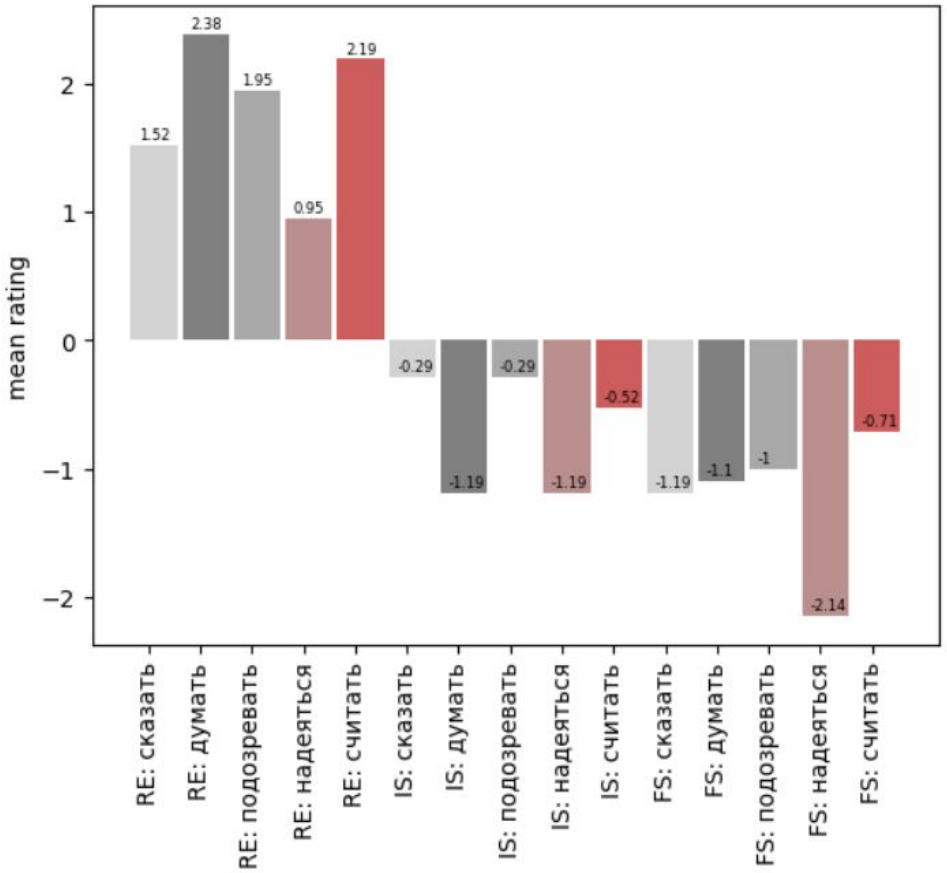
  Bella is a vampire – a proposal

  Sam is happy that Bella is a vampire – an imposition



Back to experimental results

- *dumat'* 'think', *schitat'* 'believe', *podozrevat'* 'suspect', *skazat'* 'say', *nadejat'sja* 'hope'
- Петя будет баллотироваться в Думу, Маша сказала, но это не так.
- Катя выходит замуж, Ваня думает, но это не так.
- На факультете сменят декана, Станислав подозревает, но это не так.
- Статью взяли на рассмотрение, Павел надеется, но это не так.
- Вася талантливый поэт, Фрося считает, но это не так.
- a slifting update for *Katja is getting married, Vanja said*
  Katja is getting married – a proposal
  Vanja said that Katja is getting married – an imposition
- the success of the proposal depends on the success of the imposition
- slifts can be reinterpreted as embeddings



Conclusions

- The analysis of regular embeddings and slifts in terms of impositions and proposals explains the general speaker commitment pattern

- The dynamic within the imposition-proposal pair is influenced by linguistic factors

References

AnderBois S., Brasoveanu A., Henderson R. 2015. At-Issue Proposals and Appositive Impositions in Discourse. *Journal of Semantics* 32(1). P. 93–138.

Asher N. 2000. Truth conditional discourse semantics for parentheticals. *Journal of Semantics* 17. P. 31–50.

de Marneffe M.-C., Simons M., Tonhauser J. 2019. The CommitmentBank: Investigating projection in naturally occurring discourse. In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 23, Vol. 2. P. 107–124.

Farkas D. F., Bruce K. B. 2010. On Reacting to Assertions and Polar Questions. *Journal of Semantics* 27(1). P. 81–118.

Jackendoff R. 1972. Semantic Interpretation in Generative Grammar. Cambridge, Massachusetts/London, England: MIT Press.

Koev T. 2021. Parentheticality, Assertion Strength, and Polarity. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 44 (1). P. 113–140.

Murray S. 2014. Varieties of update. *Semantics & Pragmatics* 7(2). P. 1–53.

Зализняк Анна А. О понятии импликативного типа (для глаголов с пропозициональным актантом) // Логический анализ языка. Знание и мнение. — М.: Наука, 1988. — С. 107–121.

Зализняк Анна А. Исследования по семантике предикатов внутреннего состояния / А. А. Зализняк. — München : Otto Sagner Verlag, 1992. — 201 с. — (Slavistische Beiträge ; Bd. 298).

Thank you!

1. Валентина хочет пойти в Ботанический Сад, а Даша не хочет. 2,19
2. Это хорошая идея, но я не могу её поддержать. 2,38
3. Некоторые, но не все, студенты сдали контрольную. -0,14
4. Олег хочет пойти на футбол, но не сможет. 1,86
5. Наташа думает, что пойдет дождь, а Витя считает, что будет солнечно. 1,71
6. Настя планирует пойти в клуб, но не думаю, что она пойдет. 1,95

1. У Ксении нет детей, и её младшая дочь сейчас у неё в гостях. -2,33
2. Алина старше Ильи, а Илья старше Алины. -1,24
3. Денис -- выдающийся пианист, но это не так. -2
4. Мой брат -- единственный ребёнок. -1,38
5. Ваня понял, что Оля ему изменяет, но она ему не изменяет. -0,67
6. Паша бросил курить, но раньше он не курил. -2,14